

百花王学園

— HYAKKAOU PRIVATE ACADEMY —

EPISODE 19

THE LOCKER ROOM

VOLUME 04

MAY 20XX

規則は、感情を排除する。

RULES
ABOVE
ALL

第19話：壁の反撃

19: THE WALL FIGHTS BACK

TLR-04-019



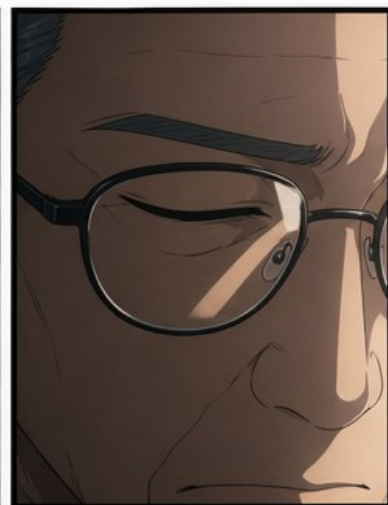
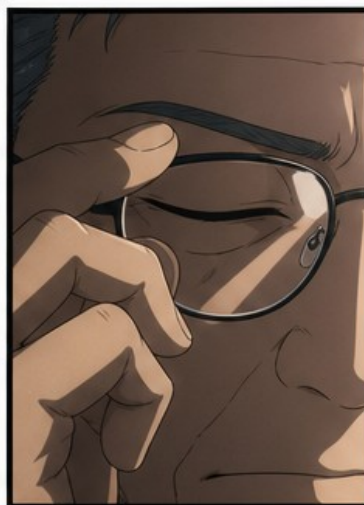
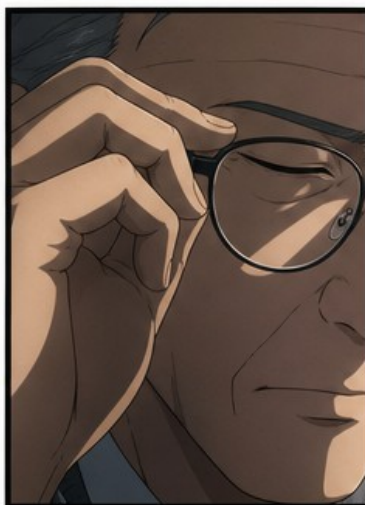
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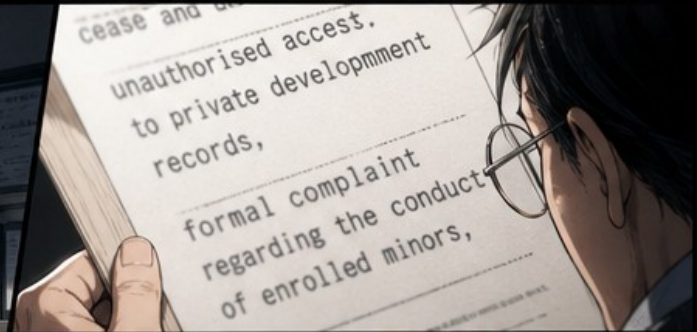


Based on the manga series "The Locker Room"
by Hyakkaou Academy Publishing

THE SYSTEM
DOES **NOT** FORGIVE.

システムは許さない。





SEIRIN PRIVATE HIGH SCHOOL
PRINCIPAL'S OFFICE
OUTSIDE THE OFFICE
AFTERNOON

A HOMEROOM
ANNOUNCEMENT
NEITHER OF THEM
EXPECTED.

KAI MORI, 17
THE READER OF TRUTH

SUMMONED TOGETHER
INTO THE SAME CRISIS.
THE FRACTURE BETWEEN
THEM STILL PRESENT.

PRINCIPAL



REIKA TENDO, 18
THE READER OF THE PAST

HER STRESS-TELL:
ONE TIGHTENING.

TIGHTEN..

KAI READS
THE CORRIDOR'S
PRESENT TRUTH
ON REFLEX.

NOTHING DRAMATIC.
NOTHING TO READ.

A SECRETARY TYPING.



A CLOCK.

THE ORDINARY
ADMINISTRATIVE HUM
OF A BUILDING
THAT HAS NO IDEA

THE DISTANCE THEY
KEEP SPEAKS LOUDER
THAN ANY DIALOGUE.
THE QUIET
AFTERSHOCK OF
EPISODE 18.

WE'VE RECEIVED
A FORMAL COMPLAINT
REGARDING UNAUTHORISED
ACCESS TO CONFIDENTIAL
DEVELOPMENT RECORDS.



KAI MORI,
17,
THE READER
OF TRUTH.

THE SCHOOL
DISTRICT HAS RECEIVED
A FORMAL COMPLAINT
REGARDING YOUR RECENT
INVOLVEMENT IN AN INCIDENT
ON SCHOOL GROUNDS.

OUR PROCEDURE
REQUIRES THAT WE
INVESTIGATE SUCH
MATTERS IMPARTIALLY,
FOR THE PROTECTION
OF ALL PARTIES
INVOLVED.

AS YOU ARE
AWARE, OUR
PRIMARY DUTY IS
TO ENSURE THE
SCHOOL IS IN FULL
COMPLIANCE WITH
BOARD POLICY AND
TO MITIGATE ANY
POTENTIAL LIABILITY.

I TRUST YOU
UNDERSTAND.

SCHOOL BOARD LIAISON

SUBJECTIVE: TRUTH READING™

BELIEVES HE IS
ACTING CORRECTLY.

FOLLOWING
PROCEDURE
EXACTLY AS
INTENDED.

PROTECTING
THE SCHOOL.

NO CONFLICT.

NO DOUBT.

NO CONCEALED
AGENDA.

NO GUILT.

100% ALIGNMENT
WITH POLICY
AND DUTY.

STRUCTURE: SOLID.
ZERO FRACTURE.
ZERO TOLERANCE.

THERE IS
NOTHING
TO READ.

NO JAGGED LINES.
NO HIDDEN GUILT.
NO LEVERAGE
POINTS.

HE TRULY BELIEVES
HE IS DOING HIS JOB
THE RIGHT WAY.

AND THAT
MAKES HIM
INCORRUPTIBLE.

WHAT
DO YOU
EXPLOIT

IN A MAN
WHO HAS
NOTHING
TO HIDE?

NAKA HAD
GUILT.

ASHIDA HAD
SOMETHING
TO FEAR.

BUT THIS MAN—
HE SLEEPS AT NIGHT
WITHOUT HESITATION.

HE LOOKS IN THE MIRROR
WITHOUT QUESTION.

THERE IS
NO CRACK.

NO WEAKNESS.

NO WAY IN.

THIS IS
WORSE.

MY GIFT FINDS
THE WARP IN TRUTH.

BUT WHAT HAPPENS
WHEN TRUTH HAS
NO WARP AT ALL?

THE PRINCIPAL'S OFFICE.
THURSDAY, 10:42 A.M.

MS. TENDO.

THANK YOU FOR
COMING IN.

THIS IS A
PROCEDURAL
REVIEW.

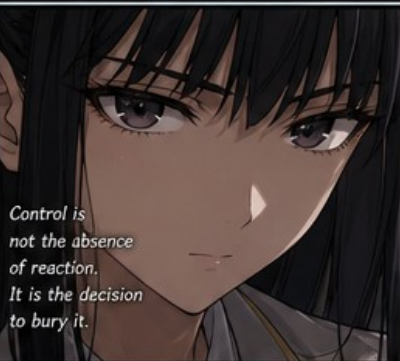
I'LL NEED YOU
TO ANSWER SOME
QUESTIONS ABOUT
YOUR ACTIVITIES ON
TUESDAY NIGHT.



REIKA TENDO, 18
THE READER OF THE PAST

Reika Tendo.
Council-President.
Model student.
Unblemished record.

And yet, here she is.
Because someone,
somewhere, thinks
that isn't enough.



Control is
not the absence
of reaction.
It is the decision
to bury it.

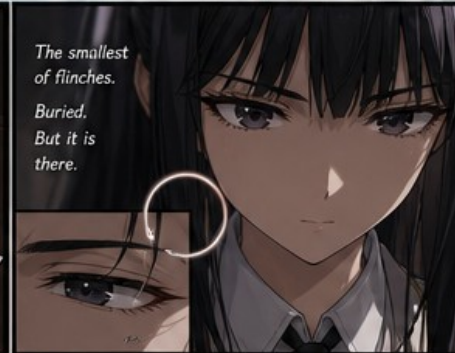


Her hands
do not move.
That is not
because she
does not feel.

It is because
she chooses
where the
weight of this
moment goes.



WE HAVE
REASON TO
BELIEVE YOU
WERE HERE.



The smallest
of flinches.
Buried.
But it is
there.



CARE TO
EXPLAIN YOUR
PRESENCE AT THE
HIGASHI-KAWAGOE
STATION?

TUESDAY,
23:17.

ALONE.



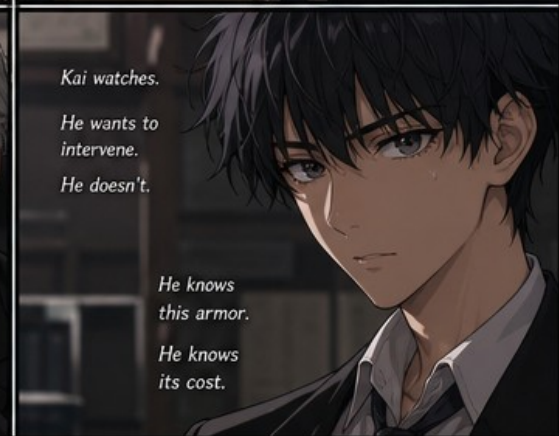
Every glance
is a calculation.
Every silence
is a choice.

Time is
the only
currency
that matters.



MS. TENDO IS
A MODEL STUDENT,
MR. SAOTOME.

I TRUST SHE
WILL COOPERATE
FULLY.



Kai watches.

He wants to
intervene.
He doesn't.

He knows
this armor.
He knows
its cost.

PRINCIPAL'S OFFICE
10:42 AM

CONTINUED
INVOLVEMENT IN MATTERS
CONCERNING THE DEVELOPMENT
SITE MAY RESULT IN FORMAL
DISCIPLINARY ACTION, A
PERMANENT NOTE IN THEIR
ACADEMIC RECORDS,

AND—

THE DEVELOPMENT
COMPANY'S LEGAL TEAM
HAS INDICATED THEY ARE
PREPARED TO PURSUE THE
MATTER THROUGH THE
COURTS IF THE SCHOOL
DOES NOT HANDLE IT
INTERNALLY FIRST.

SCHOOL BOARD
LIAISON

校長
PRINCIPAL

CLICK.

I UNDERSTAND THIS IS
NOT THE OUTCOME
YOU HOPED FOR.

PLEASE KNOW THAT
THIS DECISION WAS NOT
MADE LIGHTLY.

MY INTENT IS
ONLY TO PROTECT
THE SCHOOL AND
ITS STUDENTS.

克己復禮

THE LIAISON IS
LOCKED.
FINAL.
GIVE-LESS.
NO REVIEW.
NO EXCEPTIONS.

PRINCIPAL

THE
STRUCTURE
DOES NOT
BEND.

CLICK:

AND JUST LIKE
THAT—THE
CORRIDOR DOES
NOT CARE.



HER
COMPOSURE
CRACKS.
NOT LOUDLY.
NOT DRAMATICALLY.

JUST HALF
AN INCH
OF A
SHOULDER.

HIS
PRECISION
SHATTERS
IN SILENCE.

THE FIRST
THAW.
NOT A
SOLUTION.
NOT A
PROMISE.

JUST
A HAND.

SHE
LETS HIM.



ASTRID BRANDT.
17.
THE READER OF THE WEB.
EXCHANGE STUDENT.

THERE IS NO SUCH THING
AS COINCIDENCE.



KAI GAVE ME
THE NAME.

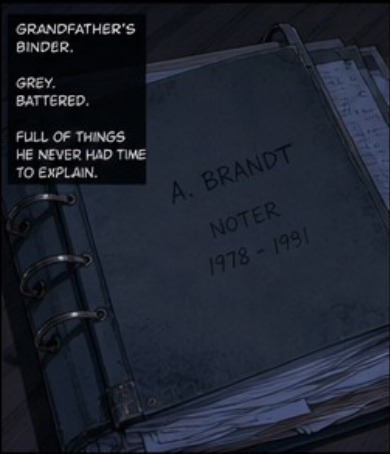
I SHOWED ME
THE MEETING.

I SHOWED ME
THE LIAISON.

SUBJECTIVE POV:
THE WEB AS IT IS.



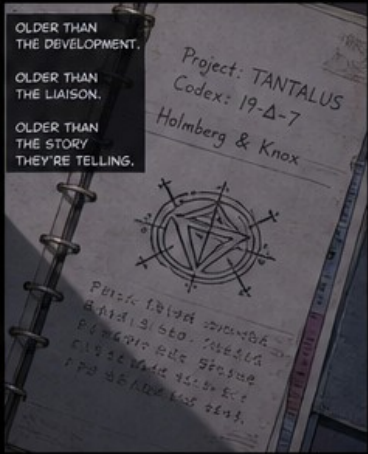
THE SAME FIRM.
THREE MUNICIPALITIES.
ONE DEVELOPERS
MACHINE.



GRANDFATHER'S
BINDER.

GREY.
BATTERED.

FULL OF THINGS
HE NEVER HAD TIME
TO EXPLAIN.



OLDER THAN
THE DEVELOPMENT.

OLDER THAN
THE LIAISON.

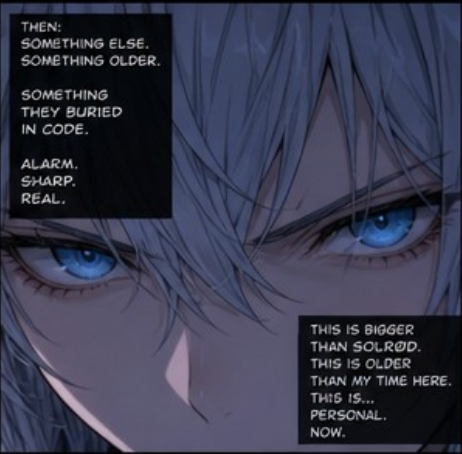
OLDER THAN
THE STORY
THEY'RE TELLING.



FIRST:
THE PATTERN
CONFIRMS.

SATISFACTION.

COLD.
CLEAN.



THEN:
SOMETHING ELSE.
SOMETHING OLDER.

SOMETHING
THEY BURIED
IN CODE.

ALARM.
SHARP.
REAL.

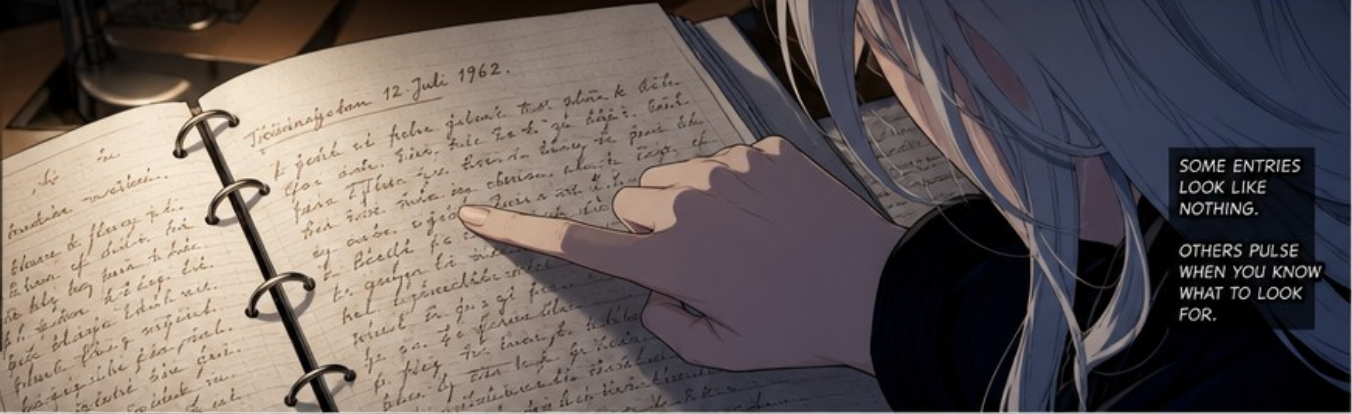
THIS IS BIGGER
THAN SOLRØD.
THIS IS OLDER
THAN MY TIME HERE.
THIS IS...
PERSONAL.
NOW.

1

ASTRID BRANDT'S
APARTMENT.
22:47.

GRANDFATHER'S
NOTES, ENCODED
IN GERMAN
SHORTHAND.

EVERY ANSWER
HE LEFT WAS
A QUESTION MARK
WE COULD ONLY
LEARN TO READ.



SOME ENTRIES
LOOK LIKE
NOTHING.

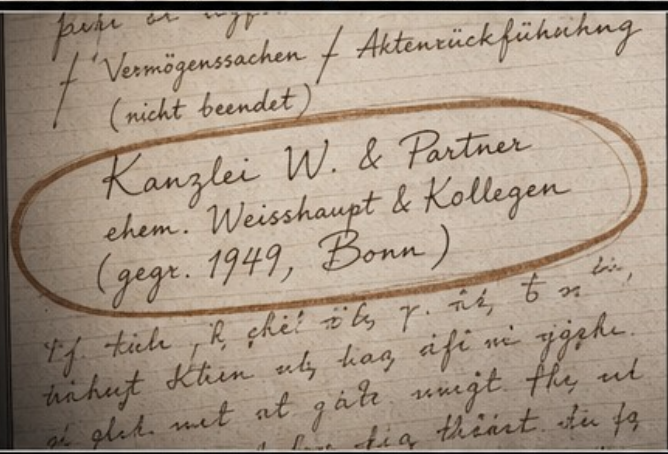
OTHERS PULSE
WHEN YOU KNOW
WHAT TO LOOK
FOR.

2

THIS ONE
WAS CIRCLED
DECADES AGO.

GRANDFATHER
KNEW ITS WEIGHT.

HE JUST DIDN'T
LIVE TO FINISH
EXPLAINING IT.



TWO NAME CHANGES.
THREE LETTERHEADS.

ONE CONTINUOUS
PRACTICE.

ESTABLISHED IN
POSTWAR WEST
GERMANY.

SPECIALIZED IN
"VERMÖGENSSACHEN."
PROPERTY MATTERS.

INCLUDING THE QUIET
ADMINISTRATIVE
WORK OF RETURNING,

OR MORE OFTEN
NOT RETURNING,
PROPERTY AND
RECORDS SEIZED
OR DESTROYED
DURING THE WAR.

3

NOT A FOREIGN
CONSPIRACY.

NOT AN
ABSTRACT EVIL.

A LAW FIRM.

OUR LAW FIRM.

WE JUST
DIDN'T KNOW
THE NAME
YET.



NOW THEY HANDLE
MUNICIPAL FILINGS
IN KYŌTO.

HOW CLEAN
IT LOOKS
ON PAPER.

HOW DIRTY
THE HISTORY
BENEATH IT.

4

DO I TELL HIM
TONIGHT?

DO I TELL HIM
THAT HIS CITY HALL
IS BUILT ON OUR
GRANDFATHER'S
FOOTNOTES?



SOME TRUTHS
DON'T JUST
CONNECT
THE PAST TO
THE PRESENT.

THEY CALL
YOU INTO
ACCOUNT.

SORA MINABE.
AGE 16.
THE READER
OF THE FUTURE.

SMALL.
UNREMARKABLE.
UNTIL THE WORLD
BECAME LEGIBLE.

SECONDHAND
THROUGH KAI'S
TEXT.

← KAI
Just heard back from
the meeting.
It's worse than we
thought.
Six weeks.
No extensions.
No exceptions.
Be ready.
16:42

NOT A SINGLE
EVENT
APPROACHING.

BUT A SLOW
TIGHTENING.

THE SENSATION
OF WALLS
CLOSING ON
A TIMELINE
RATHER THAN
A PERSON.

THE HEIRLOOM
KEY.

A CONSTANT
WARM WEIGHT
IN HIS POCKET.



FIVE FUTURES.
FIVE PATHS.
ONE DEADLINE.
ALL NARROWING
AT ONCE.

KAI'S
FUTURE

6 WEEKS

REIKA'S
FUTURE
6 WEEKS

SORA'S
FUTURE
6 WEEKS

ASTRID'S
FUTURE

6 WEEKS

INOUE'S
FUTURE
6 WEEKS

COMPRESSING
INWARD.
NOT TOWARD
ONE POINT—
BUT FROM
ALL SIDES.

PRESSURE
WITHOUT
DIRECTION.

THE SCHOOL
IS MOVING
AGAINST US.

THE DEVELOPER
IS MOVING
AGAINST US.

OUR OPTIONS
ARE RUNNING OUT
FASTER THAN
I CALCULATED.

EVEN I DIDN'T
ACCOUNT FOR
THIS VARIABLE.

ORDINARY.
QUIET.
DECEPTIVE.

Five futures.
Six weeks.
One chance.
No mistakes.
Read.
Act.
Endure.

A GIFT
NO SIXTEEN-YEAR-OLD
SHOULD BEAR.

A WEIGHT
NO ONE ELSE
CAN SEE.

THE NEXT DAY.
AFTER HOURS.

OUTSIDE THE
PRINCIPAL'S OFFICE.

REIKA SAID
THEY WERE
MEETING
TODAY.

SAID I'D
KNOW.

SO I CAME.

PRINCIPAL

IT'S HAPPENING.

NOT FROM HIM.
FROM ME.

CHARCOAL DUST.
DRIFTING FROM
MY SLEEVES.
DRAWING WHAT'S
LEFT BEHIND.

DOCUMENT
RECEIVED.

STAMP.
DATE. INITIAL.

FOR THE RECORD.

FILED.
CORRECT CATEGORY.

PROCESS
COMPLETE.

THIS ISN'T
A WOUND.

THERE'S NO
ABSENCE HERE.

THE NODE WAS
A TEAR.

SOMETHING
RIPPED AWAY.

A PLACE THAT
SHOULD HAVE
BEEN.

THIS...

THIS IS
SOMETHING
ELSE.

IT'S
RIGHT.

IT'S
CLEAN.

IT'S
CORRECT.

IT WORKED.

EXACTLY AS
IT SHOULD.

AND THAT'S
WHY IT FEELS
SO WRONG.

I DON'T KNOW
WHAT TO CALL
THIS FEELING.

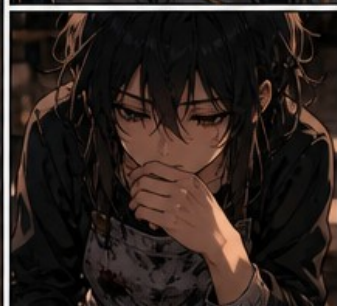
INOUE HANA, 17

ART ROOM. AFTER SCHOOL. ALWAYS.



SOME AFTERMATHS AREN'T ABSENCE.
SOME ARE SATISFACTION.

THE ART ROOM.
THAT EVENING.



- LEGAL THREAT:
INJUNCTION DENIED.
PROCEEDINGS GREENLIT.
- LIAISON REPORT:
CONSCIENCE CLEAN.
NO ETHICAL VIOLATION.
- LAW FIRM CONNECTION:
OLDER, DEEPER,
PROTECTED.
- MULTI-FUTURE ANALYSIS:
ALL BRANCHES CONVERGE
ON CATASTROPHE.
- PROCEDURAL RESIDUE:
SATISFIED, COMPLETE.
NO ANOMALIES.

THE QUESTION LANDS
INTO THE ROOM'S
COLLECTIVE DREAD.

NOBODY ANSWERS
IMMEDIATELY.

BECAUSE EVERY ANSWER
COSTS EVERYTHING.





IT PROTECTS US FROM THEIR MACHINERY...

...BUT IT MEANS SURRENDERING CONTROL.

HOW, WHEN, HOW FAR—I WON'T GET TO DECIDE ANYMORE.

ONCE IT'S OUT, IT'S OUT.

IRREVERSIBLE.

THE CONSEQUENCES... I CAN'T FULLY PREDICT.



...WE TAKE THIS PUBLIC.

NOT THROUGH THE SCHOOL. NOT THROUGH THE LIAISON.

WE GO TO A JOURNALIST.

WE MAKE IT PUBLIC BEFORE THEY CAN FINALISE ANYTHING.

THAT'S THE DECISION.

REIKA TENDO, 18
THE READER OF THE PAST



THE FUTURES DON'T STOP.

THEY JUST... REORGANISE.

THE WALLS ARE STILL CLOSING—

—BUT NOW THEY'RE CLOSING AROUND A PLAN.

SORA MINABE, 18
THE READER OF MULTIPLE FUTURES



IT'S STILL TERRIFYING.

BUT IT'S DIFFERENT NOW.

THIS TIME... WE'RE NOT WAITING.



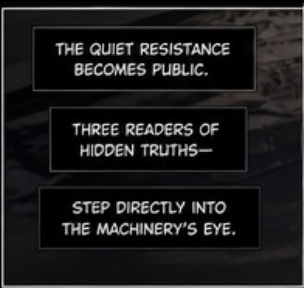
GOOD.

FEARLESS IS MORE INTERESTING THAN CAREFUL.

LET'S SEE WHO STILL ANSWERS...

...WHEN THE STORY ISN'T THEIRS TO CONTROL.

ASTRID BRANDT, 19
THE READER OF NETWORKS



THE QUIET RESISTANCE BECOMES PUBLIC.

THREE READERS OF HIDDEN TRUTHS—

STEP DIRECTLY INTO THE MACHINERY'S EYE.

THERE'S NO TAKING IT BACK AFTER THIS.

WE PROTECT EACH OTHER, AND WE TELL THE TRUTH.





Subject: Request for Comment
To: journalist@regionalreport.jp

Send



*The wall doesn't fight with hands.
It fights with forms.
So they would answer it with one.*